Metal-Sci: A Scientific Compute Benchmark for Evolutionary LLM Kernel Search on Apple Silicon

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Abstract

We present METAL-SCI, a 10-task benchmark of scientific Apple Silicon Metal compute kernels spanning six optimization regimes (stencils, all-pairs, multi-field Boltzmann, neighbor-list molecular dynamics, multi-kernel PDE, FFT). Each task ships a CPU reference, a roofline-anchored fitness function, and a held-out generalization size. We pair the benchmark with a *lightweight harness for automatic kernel search* that runtime-compiles each candidate, scores it against the roofline across multiple sizes, and feeds structured compile and per-size correctness diagnostics back to a frozen LLM driving a $(1{+}1)$ evolutionary loop. We report matched single-model sweeps of Claude Opus 4.7, Gemini 3.1 Pro, and GPT-5.5 on M1 Pro: in-distribution self-speedups span $1.00\times$ to $10.7\times$. Beyond raw speedup, our central methodological claim is structural: the held-out gate $\Phi_{\mathcal{T}}$ — evaluated once at end-of-run on a configuration the agent never sees during search — functions as a cheap mechanical oversight primitive on this $(1{+}1)$ coding agent, catching e.g. an Opus `template <uint D>` HMC win that returns wrong samples at unseen $d{=}24$ (Gemini's runtime-d fallback and GPT-5.5's $D \in \{8, 16, 24, 32\}$ enumeration generalize at $17.6\times$ and $18.6\times$), and a GPT-5.5 FFT3D best that wins in-distribution at $2.95\times$ but collapses to $0.23\times$ on a 256^3 held-out cube — a silent regression that the in-distribution score alone cannot see.

1. Introduction

LLM code-search systems such as FunSearch (Romera-Paredes et al., 2023), AlphaEvolve (Novikov et al., 2025), and recent kernel-generation work (Ouyang et al., 2025) evaluate language models as *optimisers* of executable artefacts. The choice of artefact matters: KernelBench targets PyTorch ML kernels (GEMM, attention, convolution) on CUDA, where canonical implementations are heavily represented in pretraining data and the optimisation surface is dominated by tiling and warp-level reductions.

Scientific computing exposes a different surface. Stencils are bandwidth-bound and reward halo and temporal blocking. All-pairs interactions are compute-bound and reward register blocking with shared-memory cooperative loads. Lattice Boltzmann ping-pongs nine distribution functions per cell with non-trivial pull-stream indexing. Cell-list molecular dynamics touches irregular memory through atomic counters. Hamiltonian Monte Carlo runs many chains in parallel where register pressure scales with the problem dimension d. Grad-Shafranov solvers chain a max-reduction with a variable-coefficient stencil. 3D FFTs are dominated by data-shuffle/butterfly patterns and twiddle-factor caching rather than tiling. Each pattern stresses a distinct dimension of the compiler/memory hierarchy, and canonical optimizations (Datta et al., 2008; Nyland et al., 2007; Schönherr et al., 2011; Anderson et al., 2008; Govindaraju et al., 2008) differ regime-to-regime.

We target the Apple Silicon's Metal compute pipeline. It is underrepresented in CUDA-centric training data, as frontier models reliably mishandle Metal-specific syntax such as the `[[max_total_threads_per_threadgroup]]` kernel attribute, a simple out-of-distribution generalization test. Its unified memory model removes host-device copy plumbing, enabling sub-second compile-run-verify cycles per candidate that are essential for fast evolutionary loops. And it supports rich simdgroup intrinsics (`simd_max`, `simd_broadcast`) and threadgroup-memory tiling, giving the LLM a non-trivial optimisation surface.

Contributions. (i) A 10-task scientific compute benchmark over six optimization regimes, each with a CPU reference, roofline-anchored fitness function, and multi-size generalization gate; (ii) a runtime-compiled harness that exposes compile errors, correctness diagnostics, and per-

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size GPU timing back to the LLM; and (iii) three matched single-model sweeps (Claude Opus 4.7, Gemini 3.1 Pro, and GPT-5.5) on M1 Pro that operationalise the held-out gate $\Phi_{\mathcal{T}}$ as a cheap mechanical oversight primitive on the $(1+1)$ coding agent: $\Phi_{\mathcal{T}}$ is never folded into any feedback packet seen by the LLM during search and catches confidently-wrong outputs — silent correctness violations and silent regressions — that the in-distribution score $S_{\mathcal{T}}$ alone licenses.

Background and notation. *Apple GPU vocabulary.* A *kernel* is a `.metal`-source GPU function launched from the CPU; a *threadgroup* (TG) is Apple's name for a CUDA thread block — cooperating threads sharing a scratchpad "threadgroup memory"; a *simdgroup* is the 32-thread SIMD lane group inside a threadgroup (Apple's name for a CUDA warp); the *System-Level Cache* (SLC) is the CPU/GPU-shared last-level cache ($\sim$24 MB on M1 Pro) sitting between the on-chip caches and DRAM. *Roofline.* A kernel's roofline (Williams et al., 2009) ceiling is the per-chip throughput upper bound implied by its arithmetic intensity (FLOPs per byte transferred). Kernels with low intensity are *bandwidth-bound* and cap at peak DRAM bandwidth (GB/s); high-intensity ones are *compute-bound* and cap at peak FP32 throughput (GFLOPS). We score candidates as a fraction of this hardware ceiling rather than against any hand-written baseline. *Evolution strategy.* $(\mu{=}1{+}\lambda{=}1)$, also called $(1{+}1)$, denotes the simplest evolution strategy: one parent, one mutated child per iteration; the child replaces the parent iff it scores strictly higher.

2. Benchmark tasks

METAL-SCI packages 10 tasks into six *optimisation regimes* (R1–R6, Table 1). The choice of regimes is the benchmark's central design decision: each regime stresses a structurally distinct dimension of the GPU/memory hierarchy, and its canonical recipe (Datta et al., 2008; Nyland et al., 2007; Schönherr et al., 2011; Anderson et al., 2008; Govindaraju et al., 2008) does not transfer to its neighbours. A halo-blocking move that wins R1 is useless on R2 (register tiling), R4 (atomic contention), or R6 (intra-simdgroup butterflies). For an LLM, this is the structural reason recall alone cannot solve the suite: there is no template that wins everywhere, so the model has to actually *recognise the regime* from the seed and reach for the right lever.

Each task ships (a) a Metal seed kernel, (b) a CPU reference with task-specific tolerance, (c) three in-distribution training sizes plus one held-out size, and (d) a per-size roofline ceiling in GFLOPS (compute-bound) or GB/s (bandwidth-bound). Per-task equations, ceilings, and verification details are deferred to App. A; the prose below names the lever each regime tests.

R1 – Regular stencils. Bandwidth-bound updates over a structured grid: a 5-point heat-equation stencil (8 B/cell) and a 7-point leapfrog wave equation (12 B/cell). The lever is halo handling, marching-axis choice, and 2.5D temporal blocking. `wave3d` doubles as a NaN trap — a sign or indexing error compounds over many leapfrog steps, and 10 of Opus's 13 correctness fails in Sec. 4 land here.

R2 – Compute-bound. $O(N^2)$ pair sums (`nbody`) and $O(d^2)$ matvec inside an L-step leapfrog (`hmc`), both running $\sim$20 FLOPs per memory transaction so the ceiling is peak FP32 GFLOPS. The lever is register tiling and threadgroup cooperative loads. `hmc` additionally probes the register-pressure boundary — per-thread $\mathbf{q}, \mathbf{p}, \mathbf{f}$ at $d{=}32$ is $\sim$512 B — and verifies correctness statistically (sample mean and Frobenius covariance error vs. the target Gaussian).

R3 – Multi-field, exotic memory. `lbm` is a D2Q9 Lattice Boltzmann (pull-stream + BGK collision) with nine distribution fields per cell at 72 B/cell traffic; the lever is SoA layout, push/pull streaming choice, and algebraic factorisations of the BGK relaxation (App. C dissects an FMA fold Opus discovered). `ising` is 2D Ising checkerboard Metropolis MC at 2 B/site; a precomputed accept-probability table and a counter-based Murmur-fmix32 PRNG yield bit-exact CPU/GPU agreement, so verification reduces to byte-equality on the spin array.

R4 – Irregular memory and atomics. Lennard-Jones MD with a cell-list spatial hash. Three kernels per step (`clear_cells` / `build_cells` / `step`); `build_cells` is an atomic scatter onto per-cell occupancy counters and the force kernel walks 27 neighbour cells with minimum-image periodic wrap. The lever is load balancing under uneven cell occupancy and atomic-contention mitigation.

R5 – Multi-kernel reductions. Picard iteration for the Grad-Shafranov fixed-boundary plasma equilibrium. Each outer step dispatches a max-reduction ($\psi_{\text{axis}}{=}\max\psi$) followed by a variable-coefficient 5-point stencil with a nonlinear source. The lever is the choice of in-kernel reduction strategy — single-threadgroup vs. simdgroup-tree — and how cleanly the two kernels compose across the dispatch boundary.

R6 – Data-shuffle / butterfly. 3D complex-to-complex forward FFT, dispatched as three per-axis 1D FFTs with two ping-ponged buffers. Unlike R1/R2, the optimisation surface is *data movement* rather than arithmetic: bit-reversal vs. Stockham auto-sort, twiddle-factor caching, mixed-radix (radix-4, radix-8) butterflies for fewer barriers, and intra-simdgroup permutes via `simd_shuffle_xor`.

Table 1. The 10 METAL-SCI tasks. "Optimisation lever" names the dominant move an LLM must reach for in that regime; "Train sizes" / "Held-out" are passed to the harness verbatim. $N_x \times N_y$ grids written as N^2 when square; cube edges as N^3. `saxpy` is a bandwidth smoke-test outside the regime structure, included to validate the harness.

Regime	Task	Optimisation lever	Train sizes	Held-out
R1 stencil	heat2d	halo, temporal blocking	$\{256, 512, 1024\}^2$	768^2
	wave3d	2.5D blocking, register pressure	$\{64, 160, 192\}^3$	128^3
R2 compute	nbody	register tiling, threadgroup cooperative load	$N \in \{256, 1024, 2048\}$	512
	hmc	per-thread state vs. register file	$(d,K) \in \{(8,16K),(16,4K),(32,1K)\}$	$(24,2K)$
R3 multi-field	lbm	SoA layout, BGK algebraic fold	$\{64, 128, 256\}^2$	192^2
	ising	checkerboard MC, byte-exact verify	$\{256, 1024, 2048\}^2$	1536^2
R4 atomics	lj	cell-list scatter, atomic contention	$N \in \{1.7, 4.1, 10.6\}$K	2744
R5 multi-kernel	gradshaf	in-kernel reduction + var-coef stencil	$\{65, 257, 513\}^2$	129^2
R6 butterfly	fft3d	TG bank conflicts, mixed-radix, `simd_shuffle`	$\{32, 64, 128\}^3$	256^3
(smoke)	saxpy	DRAM saturation	$\{1, 16, 64\}$M	4M

The per-axis stride asymmetry (stride 1 along x vs. N and N^2 along y, z) makes threadgroup-memory bank-conflict avoidance a separate sub-lever.

3. Harness Design

Compile and dispatch. The harness uses PyObjC's Metal bindings and runtime-compiles `.metal` source via `MTLDevice.newLibraryWithSource`, avoiding the offline `xcrun metal` toolchain; compile errors are returned as structured strings to the LLM. Buffers are allocated in unified memory; numpy views alias buffer contents with a single copy on read-back. All dispatches for a multi-size run share one `MTLCommandBuffer`, and timings come from `GPUEndTime` − `GPUStartTime` (3 warmup, 10 timed, median reported). The chip is detected from `sysctl` and looked up in a per-family table (M1 through M4) for peak FP32 GFLOPS and DRAM bandwidth; all runs here are on Apple M1 Pro (4500 GFLOPS, 200 GB/s).

Notation. A task $\mathcal{T}=(\sigma_{\mathcal{T}}, \Sigma_{\mathcal{T}}, \sigma^{\star}_{\mathcal{T}}, c_{\mathcal{T}})$ packages a naive correct seed kernel $\sigma_{\mathcal{T}}$ (Metal source), three training sizes $\Sigma_{\mathcal{T}}=\{s_1, s_2, s_3\}$, one held-out size $\sigma^{\star}_{\mathcal{T}} \notin \Sigma_{\mathcal{T}}$, and a per-size roofline $c_{\mathcal{T}}(s)$ in GFLOPS or GB/s. Evaluating a candidate κ at size s produces a correctness flag $\chi_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa, s) \in \{0, 1\}$ (CPU reference within tolerance or not) and an achieved throughput $a_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa, s)$; write $f_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa, s)=a_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa, s)/c_{\mathcal{T}}(s)$ for the per-size fraction-of-ceiling.

Scoring. The in-distribution score is the geometric mean of $f_{\mathcal{T}}$ over training sizes, gated on correctness on *every* size:

$$S_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa) \;=\; \Big(\prod_{s \in \Sigma_{\mathcal{T}}} f_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa, s)\Big)^{1/|\Sigma_{\mathcal{T}}|} \cdot \prod_{s \in \Sigma_{\mathcal{T}}} \chi_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa, s). \tag{1}$$

The hard gate ($S_{\mathcal{T}}=0$ on any tolerance failure) prevents trading correctness for speed; the gmean across sizes discourages overfit to one regime. The held-out gate, run only on the run's incumbent at end-of-run, is the analogous quantity at the unseen size: $\Phi_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa)=f_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa, \sigma^{\star}_{\mathcal{T}}) \cdot \chi_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa, \sigma^{\star}_{\mathcal{T}})$. $S_{\mathcal{T}}$ is the agent's optimisation target; $\Phi_{\mathcal{T}}$ is the external oversight signal it never sees.

Evolution loop. A frozen LLM $\mathcal{M}$ acts as a kernel synthesiser. Given a task-spec system prompt $p_{\mathcal{T}}$ and a feedback packet $\mathcal{F}_k$ summarising the previous candidate, the incumbent, and a short per-iteration history, $\mathcal{M}$ emits a Metal source

$$\kappa_{k+1} \;=\; \mathcal{M}\big(p_{\mathcal{T}},\, q(\kappa_k,\, \kappa^{\star}_k,\, \mathcal{F}_k)\big), \qquad \kappa_0 = \sigma_{\mathcal{T}}, \tag{2}$$

which the harness compiles, dispatches across $\Sigma_{\mathcal{T}}$, and scores; the strict (1+1) rule promotes $\kappa^{\star}_{k+1}=\kappa_{k+1}$ iff $S_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa_{k+1})>S_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa^{\star}_k)$, otherwise $\kappa^{\star}_{k+1}=\kappa^{\star}_k$. We formalise this compile–evaluate–promote (1+1) loop in Alg. 1 (App. B). Compile, pipeline, and per-size correctness errors are returned inside $\mathcal{F}_{k+1}$ as structured strings (the violating size, the error metric and value, and the compiler diagnostic if any). After K iterations the run terminates; both $S_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa^{\star}_K)$ and the held-out $\Phi_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa^{\star}_K)$ are reported. A single `call_llm` bridge dispatches Claude via the Agent SDK, Gemini via `google-genai`, and GPT-5.5 via the OpenAI Responses API at `reasoning_effort=high`.

4. Experiments

We run three matched single-model sweeps on Apple M1 Pro — claude-opus-4-7 (*O*), gemini-3.1-pro-preview (*G*), and gpt-5.5 (*G5*) — over the ten tasks at the same per-task iteration budget (10 each except lbm at 25 and wave3d at 15; the asymmetry tracks where the incumbent kept moving past iter 10 in pilot runs and is justified *post hoc* by Fig. 1), μ=1+λ=1, no human prompt intervention. Table 2 reports each model's in-distribution self-speedup (best / seed, gmean over three training sizes) and a held-out evaluation in which the unmodified seed and each incum-

Table 2. Matched 10/15/25-iter sweeps on Apple M1 Pro: O = claude-opus-4-7, G = gemini-3.1-pro-preview, G5 = gpt-5.5. *In-dist.* × = best / seed, gmean over three training sizes; correctness is a hard gate. *Held-out frac.* = achieved/ceiling at the unseen size, measured in a single fresh session for all three models; *held-out* × = best / seed at that size. **Bold** marks regressions ($< 0.95\times$), the HMC correctness fail, and the GPT-5.5 FFT3D collapse.

	In-dist. ×			Held-out frac.			Held-out ×			
Task	O	G	G5	O	G	G5	O	G	G5	Outcome
saxpy	1.25	1.00	1.01	93%	78%	78%	1.17	0.98	0.98	saturated
heat2d	1.00	1.03	1.00	84%	98%	80%	**0.86**	1.01	**0.82**	saturated
wave3d	1.26	1.00	1.00	97%	87%	96%	1.00	**0.90**	0.99	saturated
ising	1.13	1.00	1.09	11%	12%	10%	**0.94**	0.99	**0.88**	flat
fft3d	1.03	1.19	2.95	42%	45%	8.5%	1.12	1.20	**0.23**	**G5 silent regression**
nbody	2.83	2.00	2.19	1.6%	2.0%	1.8%	1.24	1.50	1.37	generalises
gradshaf	1.89	2.89	1.93	5.4%	7.7%	5.0%	2.05	2.91	1.86	generalises
lj	1.77	1.98	1.62	0.31%	0.47%	0.34%	1.24	1.87	1.34	generalises
lbm	1.46	1.06	1.33	79%	93%	82%	0.97	1.16	1.01	tied at 192^2
hmc	10.6	10.7	7.19	—	9.7%	10.2%	**FAIL**	17.6	18.6	**O wrong at** d=24; G,G5 clean

bent best are run on a single unseen problem size declared by the task spec (Sec. 2). The held-out columns are remeasured in a single fresh session for all three models so the absolute fraction-of-ceiling numbers stay apples-to-apples; we observed that single-size held-out fractions can shift by tens of percentage points across sessions due to GPU thermal state and SLC residency, so we anchor on the within-session ratios.

In-distribution. Self-speedups span $1.00\times$ to $10.7\times$. The HMC step (Fig. 2) is the high end *for Opus and Gemini*: each independently introduces a `template <uint D>` worker dispatched on runtime d that takes d=8 from ∼120 to ∼970 GFLOPS by enabling full unroll of the inner $A\,q$ matvec, and the two top scores agree to within 1.4% (O 0.0932 vs G 0.0870); GPT-5.5 reaches the same regime more cautiously at 7.2× (G5 0.0634). Outside HMC the models split: Opus wins on saxpy (1.25), nbody (2.83), lbm (1.46), and wave3d (1.26); Gemini wins on gradshaf (2.89) and lj (1.98); **GPT-5.5 wins fft3d outright at** $2.95\times$ (vs 1.19 Gemini, 1.03 Opus), the largest in-distribution gap any single model opens on the suite, and is competitive on nbody (2.19), gradshaf (1.93), ising (1.09), and lbm (1.33). The Opus–Gemini split correlates with the type of optimisation lever: “tune the same algorithm tighter” (BW saturation, BGK fold, leapfrog ILP) favours Opus, while “find a different algorithm” (simdgroup-tree reduction, twiddle caching, neighbour-list reorganisation) favours Gemini (see App. C for code-level diffs on lbm and fft3d, plus GPT-5.5’s FFT3D direct-DFT fallback and HMC defensive enumeration). GPT-5.5 sits closer to Gemini in temperament — it explores aggressive restructurings, which on fft3d pays off in-distribution but, as the held-out column makes visible, at the cost of a sharp overfit (§ below). Saturated tasks (saxpy, heat2d, wave3d) sit above 78% of effective DRAM ceiling on the seed; saxpy and heat2d primarily validate the harness, leaving the search loop little to do — and heat2d shows the score is a *hard* signal: on both Opus and GPT-5.5 zero candidates strictly dominated the seed across all three sizes and the incumbent stayed at iter 0. Across all three sweeps, Gemini had *zero* correctness failures across its 95 fresh-run candidates; Opus had 13 across 110 candidates (notably wave3d 10/15: multi-step leapfrog amplifies any sign or indexing error into NaN); GPT-5.5 had 2 across 120 candidates, the second-lowest correctness-failure rate of the three after Gemini.

Held-out generalisation is sharper than in-distribution — and the three models overfit asymmetrically. Three populations separate. (i) *Generalises*: nbody, gradshaf, lj, and (for O and G) fft3d. Gradshaf is the standout where all three models extrapolate cleanly ($2.05\times$ O, $2.91\times$ G, $1.86\times$ G5); on lj only Gemini exceeds its in-distribution speedup ($1.87\times$ at N=2744); Opus and GPT-5.5 hold partial gains ($1.24\times$ and $1.34\times$ respectively). (ii) *Saturated*: saxpy, heat2d, wave3d, ising, and lbm 192^2. lbm is the cleanest reclassification under our refreshed session: where an earlier measurement at the held-out grid showed both Opus and Gemini regressing to $0.41\times/0.50\times$, the single-session three-way remeasurement above puts all three within the $0.97\times$–$1.16\times$ band, with Gemini even gaining a modest $1.16\times$. The 192-square sits between the 128^2 and 256^2 training sizes, on a multiple of 32, and SLC residency at small grids dominates the absolute fraction-of-ceiling — enough to flip the within-task ordering session-to-session. We treat lbm as held-out-saturated rather than as a regression exemplar. (iii) *Overfits*, with the most consequential disagreements between the three models. **HMC** is the sharpest correctness case: Opus’s template specialisation dispatches `if (d==8) run<8>() ... else run<32>()`, so d=24 lands in the D=32 branch, per-thread `q[32], p[32]` and the unrolled matvec process 32 entries against 24-entry data, and sample covariance lands ∼10σ off target. Gemini pairs the template-D speedup with a runtime-d leapfrog fallback; GPT-5.5 goes one step further and enumerates `D∈{8,16,24,32}` explicitly (App. C), covering the held-out dimension with its own fully-unrolled template instance *and* a runtime-d safety net for any other d. Both generalise to $d{=}24$ at $\sim$10% of FP32 peak (17.6$\times$ G, 18.6$\times$ G5). **FFT3D is the sharpest *performance* case for the new model**: GPT-5.5's iter-10 best wins the in-distribution gmean at $2.95\times$ but on the held-out 256^3 cube — past the largest training size 128^3 — it collapses to $0.23\times$ of seed (8.5% of effective ceiling vs Opus's 42% and Gemini's 45% on the same configuration). The kernel relies on a fixed-twiddle, fixed-geometry layout tuned for $N{\leq}128$; at $N{=}256$ the register pressure and tg-memory budget no longer fit, and the fallback path is dramatically slower than the seed's textbook Stockham. This is the cleanest silent-regression instance in the sweep: $S_{\mathcal{T}}$ alone licenses a $2.95\times$ win, $\Phi_{\mathcal{T}}$ surfaces a $0.23\times$ deployment-grade slowdown. **GPT-5.5** is never strictly worse than Opus on held-out correctness (both clean except Opus's HMC fail) and on generalisation falls between Opus and Gemini on most tasks — but its FFT3D collapse is the largest single held-out swing in the table and exemplifies the oversight value of $\Phi_{\mathcal{T}}$ on a non-Anthropic, non-Google frontier model.

Recurring Metal-grammar failures. Compile-error patterns are similar across the three models. `[[max_total_threads_per_threadgroup(N)]]` is mis-placed (after the parameter list, or as a standalone statement, instead of on the `kernel void` declaration) on Opus across five tasks — reproduced from earlier opus-4-6 runs — and GPT-5.5 hits the same attribute placement error on its first saxpy iteration. `half` is reserved as MSL's fp16 type, breaking `uint half = N » 1u;`; C++ lambdas are unsupported. The three sweeps differ in volume rather than kind: $12/110$ compile fails for Opus, $22/95$ for Gemini, $12/120$ for GPT-5.5 — GPT-5.5 has the lowest compile-fail rate (10%) and the second-lowest correctness-fail rate (2/120) of the three; Gemini keeps its perfect $0/95$ correctness record. Wall time scales the opposite way: Opus 0.6 min/iter, Gemini 3.5 min/iter, GPT-5.5 6.6 min/iter (`reasoning_effort=high`); GPT-5.5's wider exploration and longer reasoning context costs roughly $2\times$ Gemini and $11\times$ Opus per iteration at matched budget.

5. Discussion

The held-out gate as agent oversight. The benchmark's $(1{+}1)$ loop is, modulo terminology, an autonomous coding agent: it reads a Metal source, edits it, runs it, and self-promotes its own outputs based on an internal fitness signal. A human merging the agent's incumbent into a downstream codebase sees only the in-distribution score $S_{\mathcal{T}}$ the agent reports — and $S_{\mathcal{T}}$ is gameable in two ways the held-out gate $\Phi_{\mathcal{T}}$ (Sec. 3) catches. **Silent correctness violation.** On HMC, Opus's incumbent hits $10.6\times$ with all in-distribution checks green; held out at $d{=}24$ — a problem dimension that sits between two training values and is not flagged as out-of-scope — the same code returns samples whose covariance is off by $\sim 10\sigma$. A user who trusted the reported number would ship a sampler that looks calibrated and isn't. **Silent regression.** On FFT3D GPT-5.5 reports an in-distribution win of $2.95\times$ — the largest single-model in-distribution gap in our sweep — that flips to a $0.23\times$ slowdown at the held-out 256^3 cube (the one configuration past the largest training size 128^3). The agent confidently labels its iter-10 output as a $\sim 3\times$ "improvement" over the seed; the held-out gate shows it is $4\times$ slower in deployment. Both failures share a structural shape: the agent specialised against the visible workload and reported a number that does not carry over. A single auxiliary problem instance per task — one extra dispatch, seconds of GPU time — is enough to surface both. This reframes the contribution toward the workshop's verifiability/oversight agenda: METAL-SCI's value lies less in providing a hard benchmark and more in instantiating a cheap, mechanical trust contract on top of an autonomous coding agent. The roofline anchor, per-size tolerance, and geometric mean inside $S_{\mathcal{T}}$ are the agent's scoring machinery; $\Phi_{\mathcal{T}}$ — evaluated once on $\sigma^{\star}_{\mathcal{T}}$ at end-of-run, never folded into any feedback packet $\mathcal{F}_k$ — is the lightweight oversight primitive that lets a human (or a downstream automated reviewer) catch confidently-wrong agent code before deployment.

Other observations. A roofline-anchored score answers "how close are we to the hardware?" in physical units; the gmean across sizes is hard to game by overfitting one regime. The three-model asymmetry is concrete: at matched iteration budgets the in-distribution scores are close, but each model fails the held-out gate in a different shape. Opus loses correctness at HMC $d{=}24$, GPT-5.5 loses performance at FFT3D 256^3, and Gemini — the only model with zero correctness failures across the entire 95-candidate budget and no held-out collapse beyond a borderline $0.90\times$ on wave3d — is the most robust of the three. Wall time orders the other way: Opus is $\sim 11\times$ faster per iteration than GPT-5.5 and $\sim 6\times$ faster than Gemini at matched budgets, which makes Opus the cheapest run when in-distribution speedup is the only deliverable, and Gemini/GPT-5.5 the safer choice when the output ships across configurations the training set did not cover. Apple Silicon's unified memory halves the host-side scaffolding compared to CUDA, enabling sub-second compile-run-verify cycles per candidate — which matters more than it sounds: an evolutionary loop with tens of candidates needs a fast *harness*, not a fast kernel. Metal's smaller, quirkier surface also surfaces OOD failures of CUDA-trained LLMs

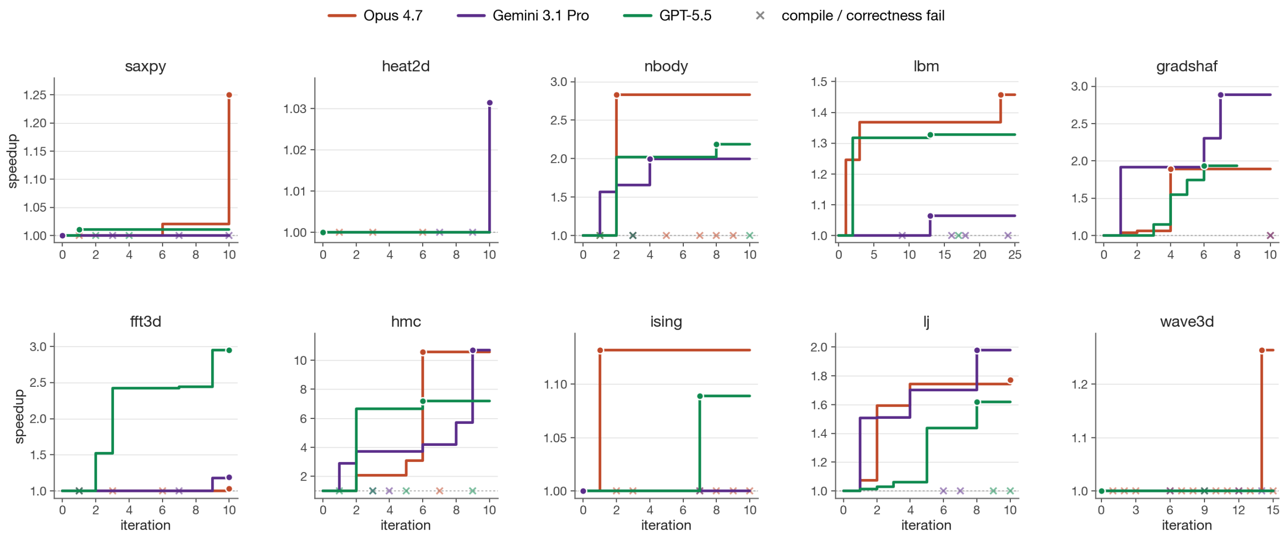

Figure 1. Per-task running self-speedup (best-so-far / seed) versus iteration, Opus 4.7 (purple) vs Gemini 3.1 Pro (green) vs GPT-5.5 (orange). Filled circles mark the iteration that achieved the final best; each x along y=1 is a candidate that compiled or ran wrong (the incumbent is unchanged) — the visible counts make the silent-correctness story concrete: Opus emits more failures than Gemini or GPT-5.5 at every task with non-trivial search (nbody, hmc, ising, lj, wave3d). The plot also justifies the asymmetric per-task budgets: on most tasks (saxpy, heat2d, nbody, gradshaf, hmc, ising, lj) the incumbent stops moving by iter ∼8 for all three models, but lbm's Opus run plateaus at 1.36× from iter 3 through iter 22 and only breaks through to 1.46× at iter 23 (the BGK fold + pinned threadgroup of App. C); wave3d's Opus run shows the same shape with the lift at iter 14 (1.26×). A 10-iter budget would have missed both Opus exemplars. GPT-5.5's fft3d, the only late-arriving in-distribution win in the new sweep, climbs monotonically through iter 10 to 2.95× — and is exactly the win that fails to generalise on the held-out gate.

```
// iter 5: runtime d, D_MAX=32 layout
for (uint i=0; i<d; ++i) {
 float4 acc = Arow[0] * q4[0];
 acc = fma(Arow[1], q4[1], acc);
 /* ... 6 more, always 8 ... */
 acc = fma(Arow[7], q4[7], acc);
 f[i] = acc.x+acc.y+acc.z+acc.w;
}
// d=8: 121 GFLOPS (2.7% of peak)
```

+ template <uint D> *compile-time D* → 8.0×

```
// iter 6: template <uint D>
template <uint D>
inline void run(...) {
 float q[D], p[D], f[D];
 #pragma unroll
 for (uint i=0; i<D; ++i) {
  float acc = 0.0f;
  #pragma unroll
  for (uint j=0; j<D; ++j)
   acc = fma(A[i*D+j], q[j], acc);
  f[i] = acc;
} }
if (d==8u) run<8u>(...);
else if (d==16u) run<16u>(...);
else       run<32u>(...);
// d=8: 970 GFLOPS (22% of peak)
```

Figure 2. Paradigmatic candidate evolution: HMC, Opus 4.7, iter 5 → 6. Both Opus and Gemini independently arrive at this structural change. The lever is one declaration — `template <uint D>` with runtime-dispatched instantiations on d. Iter 5 had a manually-unrolled float4 inner loop against a fixed $D_{\max}$=32 layout (over-computing at d=8, plus a 4-way horizontal sum); iter 6 sizes `q`, `p`, `f` exactly to D so both loops fully unroll into scalar FMAs — moving d=8 from 121 to 970 GFLOPS in one iteration after five had stalled at 2–4% of peak. Opus enumerated $D \in \{8, 16, 32\}$ and broke correctness at the held-out d=24; Gemini kept a runtime-d fallback and generalised cleanly.

on tasks that are otherwise textbook.

Limitations and future work. The static per-chip ceilings do not account for SLC residency at small sizes (see the LBM 256^2 result above); a workload-aware roofline (Williams et al., 2009) per task and per size would tighten the score. The single-population (1+1) loop plateaus within 10–25 iterations on most tasks — an island-model or FunSearch-style (Romera-Paredes et al., 2023) archive with a novelty signal (Novikov et al., 2025) is the natural next step, particularly for the irregular-memory tasks. Future tasks include sparse linear algebra (SpMV, CG) and cross-chip generalisation (evolve on M2 Pro, evaluate on M3 Max).

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A. Task formulations

This appendix gives the per-task equations, ceilings, and tolerances summarised in Section 2. Tasks are grouped by the regimes R1–R6 of Table 1; training and held-out sizes match the table.

A.1. R1: Regular stencils

heat2d. Two-dimensional heat equation, 5-point stencil on $(N_x \times N_y)$ grid with Dirichlet boundaries. Per timestep, per interior cell:

$$u_{i,j}^{n+1} \;=\; u_{i,j}^{n} + \alpha\big(u_{i-1,j}^{n} + u_{i+1,j}^{n} + u_{i,j-1}^{n} + u_{i,j+1}^{n} - 4\,u_{i,j}^{n}\big)\,. \tag{3}$$

Bandwidth-bound at 8 B/cell.

wave3d. Three-dimensional acoustic wave equation, 7-point isotropic Laplacian, leapfrog in time:

$$u_{i,j,k}^{n+1} = 2u_{i,j,k}^{n} - u_{i,j,k}^{n-1} + \alpha\left(u_{i\pm1,j,k}^{n} + u_{i,j\pm1,k}^{n} + u_{i,j,k\pm1}^{n} - 6\,u_{i,j,k}^{n}\right), \tag{4}$$

where each $\pm$ expands to two terms. CFL stability requires $\alpha = (c\Delta t/\Delta x)^2 < 1/3$ (we use 0.18). 12 B/cell unique DRAM traffic.

A.2. R2: Compute-bound

nbody. All-pairs gravitational N-body with leapfrog integration. Per body i per step:

$$\mathbf{a}_i \;=\; G\sum_j m_j \frac{\mathbf{r}_j - \mathbf{r}_i}{(\|\mathbf{r}_j - \mathbf{r}_i\|^2 + \varepsilon^2)^{3/2}}, \quad \mathbf{v} \mathrel{+}= \mathbf{a}\Delta t, \quad \mathbf{r} \mathrel{+}= \mathbf{v}\Delta t. \tag{5}$$

Self-interaction is masked by softening ε. $\sim$20 FLOPs per pair; ceiling at peak FP32 GFLOPS.

hmc. Hamiltonian Monte Carlo on an anisotropic Gaussian target, $U(q) = \frac{1}{2}q^\top Aq$ with $A = \Sigma^{-1}$. One thread per chain; many chains in parallel. Each step draws $p \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I)$ and runs L leapfrog inner steps with stepsize ε,

$$p \leftarrow p - \tfrac{\varepsilon}{2}Aq, \quad q \leftarrow q + \varepsilon p, \quad p \leftarrow p - \varepsilon Aq, \; \cdots\,, \quad p \leftarrow p - \tfrac{\varepsilon}{2}Aq, \tag{6}$$

followed by a Metropolis accept/reject with $\log u_{\mathrm{acc}} < -\Delta H$. Correctness is verified statistically (sample mean and Frobenius covariance error vs. the target). The three training sizes $(d, K) \in \{(8, 16\mathrm{K}), (16, 4\mathrm{K}), (32, 1\mathrm{K})\}$ probe the register-pressure boundary; at d=32 per-thread state ($\sim$512 B) competes with the register file.

A.3. R3: Multi-field, exotic memory

lbm. D2Q9 Lattice Boltzmann, fused pull-stream + BGK collision, periodic BC. With velocity table $\mathbf{c}_k$ and weights w_k, per cell per step:

$$f_k^{\mathrm{str}}(\mathbf{x}) = f_k^{\mathrm{in}}(\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{c}_k), \quad \rho = \textstyle\sum_k f_k^{\mathrm{str}}, \quad \mathbf{u} = \frac{1}{\rho}\sum_k \mathbf{c}_k\, f_k^{\mathrm{str}}, \tag{7}$$

$$f_k^{\mathrm{eq}} = w_k\rho\big(1 + 3(\mathbf{c}_k{\cdot}\mathbf{u}) + \tfrac{9}{2}(\mathbf{c}_k{\cdot}\mathbf{u})^2 - \tfrac{3}{2}\|\mathbf{u}\|^2\big)\,, \tag{8}$$

$$f_k^{\mathrm{out}} = f_k^{\mathrm{str}} - \tau^{-1}\big(f_k^{\mathrm{str}} - f_k^{\mathrm{eq}}\big)\,. \tag{9}$$

Storage is SoA: $f[k\,N_xN_y + jN_x + i]$. 72 B/cell DRAM traffic.

ising. Two-dimensional Ising model, checkerboard Metropolis Monte Carlo on a periodic $N_x \times N_y$ lattice with $\sigma \in \{\pm1\}$ stored as int8. Per attempt at site (i, j):

$$h = \sigma_{i\pm1,j} + \sigma_{i,j\pm1} \in \{-4, \ldots, 4\}, \quad \Delta E = 2J\sigma\,h, \quad \text{accept} \iff u < \exp(-\beta\,\Delta E). \tag{10}$$

A precomputed five-entry p_{accept} table and a counter-based Murmur-fmix32 PRNG yield bit-exact CPU/GPU agreement; verification is byte-equality on the spin array. 2 B/site/sweep ceiling.

A.4. R4: Irregular memory and atomics

lj. Lennard-Jones molecular dynamics with a cell-list spatial hash. Three kernels per step — `clear_cells`, `build_cells` (atomic scatter), `step` (27-neighbour-cell pair force + integration):

$$\mathbf{F}_i = \sum_{j\in\mathcal{N}(i)} -24\big(2r_{ij}^{-12} - r_{ij}^{-6}\big)\, r_{ij}^{-2}\,(\mathbf{r}_j - \mathbf{r}_i), \qquad r_{ij} < r_{\text{cut}} = 2.5, \tag{11}$$

with minimum-image periodic wrap. Cell occupancy is built via `atomic_fetch_add` on a per-cell counter.

A.5. R5: Multi-kernel reductions

gradshaf. Grad-Shafranov fixed-boundary equilibrium via Picard iteration, two kernels per outer step: an interior max-reduction $\psi_{\text{axis}} = \max_{(i,j)\in\text{int}} \psi$, then a variable-coefficient 5-point stencil with nonlinear source:

$$\psi_{\text{norm}} = \psi/\psi_{\text{axis}}, \quad J = R\,p_{\text{axis}} \cdot 4\psi_{\text{norm}}(1-\psi_{\text{norm}}) \cdot \mathbf{1}[0<\psi_{\text{norm}}<1], \tag{12}$$

$$\Delta^*\psi = a_W\psi_W + a_E\psi_E + a_N\psi_N + a_S\psi_S + a_C\psi_C, \tag{13}$$

$$\psi^{n+1} = \psi^n + \omega\,(-\mu_0 RJ - \Delta^*\psi)/a_C, \tag{14}$$

with R-dependent $a_{W,E} = 1/dR^2 \pm 1/(2RdR)$, $a_{N,S} = 1/dZ^2$, $a_C = -2(1/dR^2 + 1/dZ^2)$.

A.6. R6: Data-shuffle / butterfly

fft3d. 3D complex-to-complex forward FFT, fp32, on a power-of-two cube of side N. Convention is unnormalised (matches `numpy.fft.fftn`); storage is row-major `float2`$[N][N][N]$. Three named kernels — `fft3d_x`, `fft3d_y`, `fft3d_z` — are dispatched in sequence with two ping-ponged buffers, each performing a length-N 1D FFT per threadgroup of N cooperating threads:

$$Y[k_1,k_2,k_3] \;=\; \sum_{n_1,n_2,n_3=0}^{N-1} X[n_1,n_2,n_3]\,\exp\!\left(-\frac{2\pi i}{N}(k_1n_1 + k_2n_2 + k_3n_3)\right). \tag{15}$$

Sizes $N \in \{32, 64, 128\}$ cover three working-set regimes: 32^3 ($\sim$256 KB) is SLC-resident and compute-bound; 128^3 ($\sim$16 MB) DRAM-binds. $\sim 5N\log_2 N$ FLOPs per 1D FFT; effective DRAM traffic 96 B/cell across the three axis passes (16 B read + 16 B write per pass). Verification is max-norm against `numpy.fft.fftn` on a fixed seeded Gaussian input, tolerance $10^{-3}+10^{-3}\|Y\|_\infty$.

B. Evolution loop pseudocode

Algorithm 1 formalises the harness of Sec. 3. The EVALUATE subroutine is the compile–run–score pipeline: it returns either a structured failure (compile or per-size correctness, with the violating size s and the error metric so $\mathcal{M}$ can correct course inside $\mathcal{F}_{k+1}$) or a successful score $S_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa)$ together with per-size fractions-of-ceiling. The held-out $\Phi_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa_K^\star)$ is computed once at end-of-run on the unseen size $\sigma_{\mathcal{T}}^\star$ — never returned in any $\mathcal{F}_k$ — and is the oversight signal of Sec. 4.

C. Code-level evidence for the in-distribution split

The comparative claim in Section 4 is mechanistic — Opus wins by tightening the same algorithm, Gemini wins by reaching for a different one. Figure 2 instantiates that claim on HMC. This appendix instantiates it on two more tasks — one Opus-favoured (lbm), one Gemini-favoured (fft3d) — with the actual diff between each model's incumbent best.

C.1. LBM: Opus tightens BGK with FMA folds and a pinned threadgroup

Both models share the seed's pull-stream + BGK structure. The diff is local to the collision step and to the kernel attribute (Fig. 3). Opus precomputes $A = \text{fma}(-1.5, \|\mathbf{u}\|^2, 1)$ once per cell, factors the per-direction equilibrium as $A + c{\cdot}u\,(3 + 4.5\,c{\cdot}u)$ — two FMAs — and folds the relaxation into a third $\text{fma}(1{-}\omega, f_k, \omega W_k \rho\, t)$, yielding nine manually unrolled blocks. It also pins `[[max_total_threads_per_threadgroup(64)]]` on the kernel declaration, picking a 32×2 tile aligned to the simdgroup width. Gemini keeps the textbook BGK formula $w_k\rho(1{+}3c{\cdot}u{+}4.5(c{\cdot}u)^2{-}1.5\|\mathbf{u}\|^2)$ inside

Algorithm 1 METAL-SCI evolution loop (μ=1+λ=1).

Require: task $\mathcal{T}$=$(\sigma_{\mathcal{T}}, \Sigma_{\mathcal{T}}, \sigma^{\star}_{\mathcal{T}}, c_{\mathcal{T}})$, LLM $\mathcal{M}$, system prompt $p_{\mathcal{T}}$, iterations K
Ensure: incumbent $\kappa^{\star}_K$, in-dist score $S_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa^{\star}_K)$, held-out $\Phi_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa^{\star}_K)$

$\kappa^{\star}_0 \leftarrow \sigma_{\mathcal{T}}$; $\quad \mathcal{F}_0 \leftarrow$ EVALUATE$(\sigma_{\mathcal{T}},\, \mathcal{T})$ ▷ seed is initial incumbent
for $k = 1, \ldots, K$ **do**
  $\kappa_k \leftarrow \mathcal{M}\big(p_{\mathcal{T}},\, q(\kappa_{k-1}, \kappa^{\star}_{k-1}, \mathcal{F}_{k-1})\big)$ ▷ propose
  $r_k \leftarrow$ EVALUATE$(\kappa_k,\, \mathcal{T})$
  $\mathcal{F}_k \leftarrow (\kappa_k,\, r_k)$ ▷ structured feedback for next iter
  if $r_k.score$ defined $\wedge$ $r_k.score > S_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa^{\star}_{k-1})$ **then**
    $\kappa^{\star}_k \leftarrow \kappa_k$ ▷ (1+1) promote
  else
    $\kappa^{\star}_k \leftarrow \kappa^{\star}_{k-1}$
  end if
end for
$\Phi_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa^{\star}_K) \leftarrow f_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa^{\star}_K,\, \sigma^{\star}_{\mathcal{T}}) \cdot \chi_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa^{\star}_K,\, \sigma^{\star}_{\mathcal{T}})$ ▷ never given to $\mathcal{M}$
return $\kappa^{\star}_K,\, S_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa^{\star}_K),\, \Phi_{\mathcal{T}}(\kappa^{\star}_K)$

function EVALUATE$(\kappa,\, \mathcal{T})$
  lib, $e_c \leftarrow$ COMPILE(κ)
  if $e_c \neq \emptyset$ **then return** $(compile\_fail,\, e_c)$
  end if
  for $s \in \Sigma_{\mathcal{T}}$ **do**
    $(\chi_s,\, a_s) \leftarrow$ RUN(lib, s)
    if $\chi_s = 0$ **then return** $(correct\_fail,\, s,$ error metric$)$
    end if
  end for
  $S \leftarrow \big(\prod_{s \in \Sigma_{\mathcal{T}}} a_s / c_{\mathcal{T}}(s)\big)^{1/|\Sigma_{\mathcal{T}}|}$
  return $\big(score\!: S,\, \{a_s/c_{\mathcal{T}}(s)\}_{s \in \Sigma_{\mathcal{T}}}\big)$
end function

```
// Opus: BGK fold + pinned geometry
[[max_total_threads_per_threadgroup(64)]]
kernel void lbm_step(...) {
 // pull-stream f0..f8, moments rho, ux, uy
...
 float A = fma(-1.5f, usq, 1.0f);
 float orWS = (omega * W_S) * rho;
 // k=5: cu = ux+uy
 {
  float cu = ux + uy;
  float t = A + cu * fma(4.5f, cu, 3.0f);
  q5[idx] = fma(one_m_w, f5, orWD * t);
 }
 // 8 more directions, same shape ...
}
```

```
// Gemini: textbook BGK in unrolled loop
kernel void lbm_step(...) {
 // pull-stream f[k], moments rho, ux, uy ...
 float usq = ux*ux + uy*uy;
 float inv_tau = 1.0f / tau;
 #pragma unroll
 for (int k = 0; k < 9; ++k) {
  float cu = CX[k]*ux + CY[k]*uy;
  float feq = W[k] * rho *
   (1.0f + 3.0f*cu + 4.5f*cu*cu
      - 1.5f*usq);
  f_out[k*N+idx] =
   f[k] - inv_tau*(f[k]-feq);
 }
}
```

Figure 3. LBM iter-23 best, Opus (left) vs Gemini iter-13 best (right). Opus extracts A once, folds f_k^{eq} into two FMAs per direction and the relaxation into a third, and pins the threadgroup geometry; Gemini stays with the canonical BGK formula and the default geometry. In-distribution gmean: Opus 0.576 vs Gemini 0.553.

a `#pragma unroll for (k=0...8)`, no FMA folds, no A-extraction, no threadgroup pin. The two are competitive at 64^2 (O 0.34, G 0.32) and Gemini actually wins at 128^2 (O 0.47, G 0.51); Opus pulls ahead at 256^2 (O 1.22, G 1.03), the cache-resident regime where the pinned 32×2 geometry and the FMA-folded BGK extract every issued instruction — and that is the size with the largest absolute fraction-of-ceiling, so it dominates the gmean.

```
// Opus: Stockham radix-4, all in tg memory
for (uint s = 0u; s < stages4; ++s) {
 // load 4 inputs from cur[]
 float2 x0 = cur[b + 0u*Nq];
 float2 x1 = cur[b + 1u*Nq];
 float2 x2 = cur[b + 2u*Nq];
 float2 x3 = cur[b + 3u*Nq];
 // twiddle multiplies (skip s=0)
 if (s != 0u) { ... }
 // 4-point DFT, write to nxt[]
 threadgroup_barrier(mem_threadgroup);
 swap(cur, nxt);
}
```

```
// Gemini: simd_shuffle_xor for stages 1..5
// (no shared mem, no barrier)
if (logN >= 1u) {
 float2 v = simd_shuffle_xor(u, 1u);
 u = ((i & 1u)==0u) ? (u+v) : (v-u);
}
// stages 2..4 analogous (xor 2, 4, 8)
if (logN >= 5u) {
 float2 v = simd_shuffle_xor(u, 16u);
 // twiddle, butterfly ...
 u = ((i & 16u)==0u) ? (u+t) : (v-t);
}
// stages s>=6: fall back to tg memory
for (uint s = 6u; s <= logN; ++s) { ... }
```

Figure 4. FFT3D iter-10 best, Opus (left) vs Gemini iter-10 best (right). Opus implements Stockham radix-4 with threadgroup-memory ping-pong and a barrier per stage; Gemini exploits the 32-wide simdgroup to do the first five stages with `simd_shuffle_xor`, eliminating five barriers per 1D FFT. In-distribution gmean: Opus 0.167 vs Gemini 0.282.

```
// Dispatch in fft3d_x kernel
threadgroup float2 buf0[128];
threadgroup float2 buf1[128];
if (N == 32u)
 fft_line_32_io(...);
else if (N == 64u)
 fft_line_64_io(..., buf0);
else if (N == 128u)
 fft_line_128_io(..., buf0, buf1);
else {
 // held-out N=256 lands here
 fft_line_direct_fallback_io(...);
}
```

```
// fft_line_direct_fallback_io: O(N^2) DFT
float2 acc = float2(0.0f, 0.0f);
float theta = -TWO_PI * float(tid) / float(N);
float2 wstep = float2(cos(theta),
sin(theta));
float2 w = float2(1.0f, 0.0f);
for (uint n = 0u; n < N; ++n) {
 float2 v = in_data[in_base + n*in_stride];
 acc += cmul(v, w);
 w = cmul(w, wstep);
}
out_data[out_base + tid * out_stride] = acc;
```

Figure 5. GPT-5.5 FFT3D iter-10 best: hand-coded `fft_line_32/64/128` routines (left dispatch) deliver the $2.95\times$ in-distribution self-speedup; for any N outside $\{32, 64, 128\}$ the kernel falls into a textbook direct $O(N^2)$ DFT (right). At held-out N=256 this costs $\sim$32$\times$ more arithmetic per output than the seed's $O(N \log N)$ Stockham FFT, producing the $0.23\times$ held-out slowdown reported in Table 2. The fast paths reuse a 64-entry `constant float2 W128[]` twiddle table whose stride indexing only covers $N \leq 128$ — the structural reason the fallback is direct DFT rather than a longer FFT.

C.2. FFT3D: Gemini swaps the algorithm to `simd_shuffle_xor`

The fft3d gmean gap is larger (0.282 vs 0.167, 1.7×), and the diff is not a tighter version of the same kernel — Fig. 4 shows two different algorithms. Opus implements a textbook Stockham auto-sort radix-4 FFT: every stage ping-pongs through threadgroup memory, with a barrier between stages. Gemini observes that for the first five Cooley–Tukey stages the butterfly partner of lane i is at lane $i \oplus 2^{s-1}$ where $s \in \{1, \ldots, 5\}$, and $2^{s-1} < 32$ — so it can be fetched with `simd_shuffle_xor`, no shared memory and no barrier. Only stages $s \geq 6$ fall back to threadgroup memory. The Apple GPU's simdgroup width is exactly 32: this trick is Metal-specific (`simd_shuffle_xor` maps to a single hardware permute), and worth ~ 5 barriers per length-N FFT, ~ 15 per 3D transform. The same "find a different memory primitive" move shows up smaller-scale on gradshaf: both models converge on a simdgroup-tree max-reduction, but Gemini additionally casts `psi` to `float4*` and reads four scalars per transaction in the inner sweep, halving the number of issued loads on the dominant kernel.

C.3. GPT-5.5 FFT3D: hand-coded fast paths for $N \leq 128$, $O(N^2)$ direct DFT for everything else

GPT-5.5's iter-10 FFT3D best wins the in-distribution gmean ($2.95\times$, vs Opus $1.03\times$ and Gemini $1.19\times$) with hand-coded `fft_line_32/64/128` routines that use `simd_shuffle_xor` (the same simdgroup primitive Gemini reaches for) for the intra-simdgroup stages and a precomputed `constant float2 W128[64]` twiddle table for the per-stage multiplies. The held-out collapse comes from a single line in the dispatch: when N does not match one of $\{32, 64, 128\}$ the kernel falls into a textbook direct $O(N^2)$ DFT (Fig. 5). At N=256 that path performs 256 complex multiplies per output element instead of the seed's $\log_2(256)$=8 butterfly stages; per 1D line this is a $\sim$32$\times$ arithmetic blow-up, and three 1D passes per 3D transform compound it. The held-out gate $\Phi_{\mathcal{T}}$ surfaces the resulting $0.23\times$ slowdown that the in-distribution score $S_{\mathcal{T}}$ alone licenses.

```
// hmc_step kernel dispatch (GPT-5.5 iter-3 best)
load_A_transpose_tg(A, AT, d, tid, tpg);
threadgroup_barrier(mem_flags::mem_threadgroup);
if (d == 8u) run_hmc_fixed_chunk8<8u >(...);
else if (d == 16u) run_hmc_d16(...);        // specialised d=16 path
else if (d == 24u) run_hmc_fixed_chunk8<24u>(...); // covers held-out d
else if (d == 32u) run_hmc_fixed_chunk8<32u>(...);
else          run_hmc_dynamic(..., d, ...);  // runtime-d safety net
```

Figure 6. GPT-5.5 HMC iter-3 best: explicit $D\in\{8, 16, 24, 32\}$ enumeration with a runtime-d catch-all. The `run_hmc_fixed_chunk8<24u>` branch is the held-out dimension's own fully-templated instance — the inner matvec, leapfrog ILP, and per-thread `q[D]`, `p[D]` register allocations all use D=24 rather than rounding up to 32 (Opus) or staying runtime (Gemini). In-distribution gmean comes in lower than Opus or Gemini (0.0634 vs 0.0932, 0.0870) — the cost of emitting four template instantiations plus a runtime fallback — but the held-out d=24 runs at 10.2% of FP32 peak, 18.6× the seed.

C.4. GPT-5.5 HMC: defensive D enumeration covering d=24

On HMC GPT-5.5 lands at a structurally different point than either Opus or Gemini. Opus enumerates only $D\in\{8, 16, 32\}$ and dispatches d=24 to the D=32 branch (Fig. 2), silently running an unrolled matvec against the wrong size. Gemini keeps a pure runtime-d leapfrog with no template specialisation, paying for safety with in-distribution throughput. GPT-5.5 takes the union: an explicit $D\in\{8, 16, 24, 32\}$ enumeration with fully-templated instances for each, plus a generic runtime-d fallback for anything outside that set (Fig. 6). The D=24 branch is the cleanest defensive move in the suite — the held-out dimension is treated as a first-class instantiation rather than a special case to round up or fall back on.

D. Related work

D.1. LLM-driven kernel-generation benchmarks

A wave of benchmarks has emerged for evaluating LLMs as generators of high-performance GPU kernels. *KernelBench* (Ouyang et al., 2025) targets PyTorch ML kernels (GEMM, attention, convolution, normalisation, activation) on CUDA and scores single-shot generation by speedup against the PyTorch eager baseline. *TritonBench* (Li et al., 2025) extends to the Triton DSL and adds reference code-similarity to correctness and performance. *BackendBench* (Saroufim et al., 2025) evaluates correctness alone for kernels written against the PyTorch backend interface. *MultiKernelBench* (Wen et al., 2025) broadens the platform set to CUDA, Ascend C, and Pallas while retaining the ML-operator workload set. *NPUEval* (Kalade & Schelle, 2025) targets the AMD AIE NPU in C++ and exposes a tool-use feedback loop with multi-turn regeneration. Most recently, *KernelCraft* (Nie et al., 2026) benchmarks bare-metal assembly kernel generation on emerging accelerator ISAs (PLENA, AMD NPU, Coral NPU, Sonic BOOM), with native tool interfaces (`check_syntax`, `run_evaluation`, `view_output`, `grep_docs`) and a three-tier ML-task taxonomy (primitive, composite, end-to-end). Across these benchmarks the workload is ML and the headline number is speedup against a vendor or compiler baseline.

D.2. LLM-driven evolutionary code search

The broader paradigm of LLMs as *optimisers* inside evolutionary code-search loops was established by *FunSearch* (Romera-Paredes et al., 2023) for symbolic-algorithm discovery and scaled by *AlphaEvolve* (Novikov et al., 2025) across mathematical and algorithmic domains. *AI CUDA Engineer* (Lange et al., 2025) and *EvoEngineer* (Guo et al., 2025) specialise this paradigm to CUDA kernel optimisation, replacing single-shot or agentic regeneration with a population/archive driven by a fitness signal — closer in spirit to our (μ=1+λ=1) loop, but on CUDA ML kernels rather than Apple Silicon scientific kernels.

D.3. Where METAL-SCI differs

Existing kernel-generation benchmarks share three structural choices that METAL-SCI deviates from. *(i) Workload domain.* All listed benchmarks target ML operators, where the optimisation surface is dominated by tiling and warp-level reduction patterns heavily represented in pretraining data. METAL-SCI targets scientific compute — regular and irregular stencils, all-pairs interactions, multi-field Boltzmann updates, neighbour-list molecular dynamics, parallel-chain MCMC, multi-kernel nonlinear PDE solvers, and butterfly spectral transforms — six structurally distinct optimisation regimes (R1–R6 of Section 2) whose canonical recipes (Datta et al., 2008; Nyland et al., 2007; Schönherr et al., 2011; Anderson

Table 3. METAL-SCI versus existing LLM kernel-generation benchmarks across the axes that drive the design of our harness. *Domain*: ML = neural-network operators (GEMM, attention, convolution, normalisation, activation); HPC = scientific compute (stencil, N-body, LBM, MD, MCMC, PDE solver, FFT). *Score basis*: what *achieved* is normalised against. *Multi-size*: whether the score requires generalisation across problem sizes. *Search*: the loop structure exposed to the LLM. Within the ML row, all listed benchmarks span a single optimisation regime (matmul-style, with norm/activation epilogues); METAL-SCI spans six structurally distinct regimes (R1–R6 of Section 2).

Benchmark	Target	Domain	Score basis	Multi-size	Search
KernelBench (Ouyang et al., 2025)	CUDA	ML	PyTorch speedup	—	single-shot
TritonBench (Li et al., 2025)	Triton DSL	ML	speedup + code-sim	—	single-shot
BackendBench (Saroufim et al., 2025)	PyTorch backend	ML	correctness only	—	single-shot
MultiKernelBench (Wen et al., 2025)	CUDA / Ascend C / Pallas	ML	compiler speedup	—	multi-turn
NPUEval (Kalade & Schelle, 2025)	AIE C++ (AMD NPU)	ML	compiler speedup	—	tool-use
KernelCraft (Nie et al., 2026)	accelerator asm	ML	compiler speedup	cfg. vars	agentic tool-use
METAL-SCI (ours)	**Apple Metal MSL**	**HPC**	**% of roofline**	**3 in + 1 held-out**	**evolutionary** $(1{+}1)$

et al., 2008; Govindaraju et al., 2008) do not transfer between regimes. *(ii) Score basis.* All listed benchmarks normalise *achieved* against a vendor or compiler baseline (PyTorch eager, compiler-emitted code, expert hand-tuned reference). This couples the headline number to the strength of that baseline. METAL-SCI normalises against the per-chip roofline ceiling (peak FP32 GFLOPS, peak DRAM GB/s), a hardware-anchored target independent of any reference implementation, with a hard correctness gate ($S{=}0$ on tolerance failure) and a geometric mean across three problem sizes that discourages overfit to a single working-set regime. *(iii) Hardware.* No listed benchmark targets Apple Silicon's Metal compute pipeline. Metal is structurally underrepresented in CUDA-centric pretraining data and surfaces a real out-of-distribution generalisation test on Metal-grammar and Metal-stdlib idioms — the `[[max_total_threads_per_threadgroup]]` attribute placement (Sec. 4, seven independent reproductions across five tasks within the opus-4-7 sweep, recurring in earlier opus-4-6 and gemini-3.1-pro runs), `half` as a reserved fp16 keyword, the absence of C++ lambdas, the availability of `simd_shuffle_xor` for intra-simdgroup butterflies, and the absence of `sincospi`. Table 3 summarises these axes against the comparator set.